

WEEKLY BUSINESS SESSION – June 17, 2026

9:00 a.m. – Anne Basker Auditorium
600 N.W. Sixth Street, Grants Pass, OR 97526

Present: Ron A. Smith, Chair-Commissioner; Colene M. Martin, Vice-Chair-Commissioner and Gary L. Richardson, Commissioner, Nikole Guzman, Recorder

These are meeting minutes only. Only text enclosed in quotation marks reports a speaker's exact words.

Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 9:00 a.m. followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

Items discussed were as follows:

1. **CALL MEETING TO ORDER:** Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 9:00 a.m.
2. **DECLARE A POTENTIAL CONFLICT OF INTEREST:** The commissioners reserved their right to declare a potential conflict of interest
3. **Public Hearing: First Reading of Ordinance No. 2026-001; An Ordinance Amending Chapter 2.05 of the County Code Relating to the Meetings of the Board of Commissioners**

Commissioner Smith opened the public hearing at 9:01 a.m.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to Ordinance No. 2026-001 read by title only. Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Wally Hicks, County Legal Counsel, reviewed the proposed ordinance and explained that the amendment would remove portions of County Code pertaining to executive sessions while retaining references to applicable Oregon Public Meetings Law and the Josephine County Charter. Hicks explained that the change was intended to provide flexibility as public meeting laws continue to evolve through legislative action, court decisions, and guidance from the Oregon Attorney General. Hicks noted that the proposal would simplify the County Code while maintaining compliance with governing law. Commissioners discussed the proposed amendment and expressed support for relying upon state law and charter provisions rather than maintaining potentially outdated local language.

Commissioner Smith opened the floor to Public Testimony: (Each person given Three (3) Minutes to speak):
None heard

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to move Ordinance No. 2026-001 to the Second Reading July 1, 2026, Seconded by Commissioner Martin. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Public Hearing closed at 9:06 a.m.

4. **Public Hearing: Josephine County 4-H/Extension Service District for Fiscal Year 2026-2027**

Commissioner Smith opened the public hearing at 9:07 a.m.

Arthur O'hare, Budget Officer, explained that the Budget Committee reviewed and approved the proposed budget on June 4, 2026. O'Hare stated that the budget had been published as required by Oregon Budget Law and was scheduled for formal adoption on June 24, 2026. He thanked Oregon State University Extension staff and Jamie Davis for their assistance in preparing the budget.

Commissioner Smith opened the floor to Public Testimony: (Each person given Three (3) Minutes to speak):
Judy Aherns, Josephine County, provided testimony regarding public awareness of budget information and encouraged continued support for 4-H youth programs. Written testimony was also received from Deb Berg and Gene Monk in support of the Extension Service District, emphasizing the value of extension programs, agricultural education, youth development opportunities, and community services provided through Oregon State University Extension.

Public Hearing closed at 9:13 a.m.

5. Public Hearing: Josephine County Law Enforcement Service District for Fiscal Year 2025-2026

Commissioner Smith opened the public hearing at 9:13 a.m.

Arthur O'Hare, Budget Officer, reported that the Budget Committee reviewed and approved the proposed budget on June 4, 2026 and that formal adoption was scheduled for June 24, 2026. O'Hare thanked the Law Enforcement Service District Advisory Committee for its participation in the budget process

Commissioner Smith opened the floor to Public Testimony: (Each person given Three (3) Minutes to speak):
None heard

Public Hearing closed at 9:14 a.m.

6. ADMINISTRATIVE ACTION(S) IN CONSIDERATION OF:

- a. Approval of Order No. 2026-031; In the Matter of the Transfer of County Real Property; Execution of Quitclaim Deed from Josephine County to ARFG Metals Trading Bonanza, LLC for transfer of County Real Property; Cabin at 710 Upper Powell Creek.

Helene Lulich, Property Manager, presented a proposed transfer of County-owned improvements located on Bureau of Land Management property at 710 Upper Powell Creek Road. Lulich explained that the County acquired the mining cabin through foreclosure in 1999 and had unsuccessfully attempted to transfer ownership to the Bureau of Land Management. Due to deteriorated conditions, safety concerns, and potential liability associated with the structures, staff recommended transferring the County's interest through a quitclaim deed. The prospective purchaser acknowledged responsibility for all liabilities and conditions associated with the property. Commissioners discussed the property's condition and agreed that transferring the improvements would eliminate future liability to the County.

- b. Resolution No. 2026-028 In the Matter of Consenting to The Change in Assignment of Southern Oregon Sanitation, Inc.

Trent Carpenter, representing Southern Oregon Sanitation, presented information regarding the pending transfer of ownership of Southern Oregon Sanitation to Waste Connections. Carpenter explained that ownership would change while local operations, employees, equipment, service levels, franchise obligations, and customer service functions would remain unchanged. He stated that the transaction was anticipated to close on August 1, 2026 and emphasized that any future rate adjustments would continue to be subject to existing franchise review and approval processes. Commissioners expressed appreciation to the Carpenter family for decades of service to Josephine County and acknowledged the company's long-standing commitment to the community.

- c. Order No. 2026-032; In the Matter of Administrative Policies and Procedures for Josephine County for the Purpose of Conducting Business on a Daily Basis; Administrative Policy A-04; *Approval Authority Thresholds & Criteria*
- d. Order No. 2026-033; In the Matter of Administrative Policies and Procedures for Josephine County for the Purpose of Conducting Business on a Daily Basis; Administrative Policy A-07; *Advisory Bodies*
- e. Order No. 2026-034; In the Matter of Administrative Policies and Procedures for Josephine County for the Purpose of Conducting Business on a Daily Basis; Administrative Policy D-02; *Position Requisitions*
- f. Order No. 2026-035; In the Matter of Administrative Policies and Procedures for Josephine County for the Purpose of Conducting Business on a Daily Basis; Administrative Policy D-03; *Personnel Actions*

- g. Order No. 2026-036; In the Matter of Administrative Policies and Procedures for Josephine County for the Purpose of Conducting Business on a Daily Basis; Personnel Policy Manual Revision; *Travel*
- h. Order No. 2026-037; In the Matter of Administrative Policies and Procedures for Josephine County for the Purpose of Conducting Business on a Daily Basis; Personnel Policy Manual Revision; *Animals in the Workplace*

Legal Counsel Wally Hicks presented a series of proposed amendments to the County's Administrative Policy Manual and Personnel Policy Manual. Hicks explained that the revisions were intended to streamline administrative processes, improve efficiency, and clarify authority within County operations. Changes included revisions to contract approval authority, advisory body appointments and removals, position requisition procedures, personnel actions, travel authorization procedures, and workplace animal policies. Commissioners discussed the proposed revisions and noted that many of the changes restored practices previously utilized by the County while reducing administrative burdens on staff and department heads.

7. **REQUESTS/COMMENTS FROM CITIZENS:** *(Each person will be given three (3) minutes to speak)*
Judy Aherns, Grants Pass, encouraged public participation in the upcoming Independence Day reading of the Declaration of Independence and discussed community efforts to improve litter cleanup and beautification efforts throughout Josephine County. She also commented on broader issues affecting communities throughout Oregon and encouraged civic engagement and patriotism.
Marc Kirby, Josephine County, expressed concern regarding proposed changes to County personnel policies, specifically revisions involving position requisitions and personnel actions. Kirby encouraged the Board to retain oversight authority over personnel decisions and stated his belief that such responsibilities should remain directly with the Board of Commissioners.

BOARD MAY REVIEW PUBLIC COMMENTS/QUESTIONS:

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Order No. 2026-031; In the Matter of the Transfer of County Real Property; Execution of Quitclaim Deed from Josephine County to ARFG Metals Trading Bonanza, LLC for transfer of County Real Property; Cabin at 710 Upper Powell Creek. Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Resolution No. 2026-028; In the Matter of Consenting to the Change in Assignment of Southern Oregon Sanitation, Inc. Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Order No. 2026-032; In the Matter of Administrative Policies and Procedures for Josephine County for the Purpose of Conducting Business on a Daily Basis; Administrative Policy A-04; Approval Authority Thresholds & Criteria. Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Order No. 2026-033; In the Matter of Administrative Policies and Procedures for Josephine County for the Purpose of Conducting Business on a Daily Basis; Administrative Policy A-07; Advisory Bodies. Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Order No. 2026-034; In the Matter of Administrative Policies and Procedures for Josephine County for the Purpose of Conducting Business on a Daily Basis; Administrative Policy D-02; Position Requisitions. Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner

Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Order No. 2026-035; In the Matter of Administrative Policies and Procedures for Josephine County for the Purpose of Conducting Business on a Daily Basis; Administrative Policy D-03; Personnel Actions. Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Order No. 2026-036; In the Matter of Administrative Policies and Procedures for Josephine County for the Purpose of Conducting Business on a Daily Basis; Personnel Policy Manual Revision; Travel. Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Order No. 2026-037; In the Matter of Administrative Policies and Procedures for Josephine County for the Purpose of Conducting Business on a Daily Basis; Personnel Policy Manual Revision; Animals in the Workplace. Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

8. APPROVAL OF CONSENT CALENDAR:

a. Minutes (*Draft minutes are available for viewing in the Board's Office*)

General Discussion – June 8, 2026

Admin Workshop – June 9, 2026

Budget Committee – June 9, 2026

Weekly Business Session – June 10, 2026

Legal Counsel Update – June 11, 2026

Animal Shelter Advisory Committee – April 2, 2026

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve the Consent Calendar, seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

9. OTHER: (ORS 192.640(1)) “. . . notice shall include a list of the principal subjects anticipated to be considered at the meeting, but this requirement shall not limit the ability of a governing body to consider additional subjects.”)

a. Budget 5 Year Projection Plan

Commissioner Richardson presented a five-year financial projection for Josephine County and discussed anticipated budget challenges associated with personnel costs, health insurance, PERS obligations, and revenue growth. Richardson noted that while the Fiscal Year 2026-2027 budget is balanced, future fiscal years are projected to experience increasing budget pressures requiring ongoing evaluation of County services and expenditures. Discussion occurred regarding assumptions used in the projection, property tax growth trends, and the importance of long-range financial planning.

10. ANNOUNCEMENTS: MATTERS FROM COMMISSIONERS:

Commissioner Richardson announced upcoming events including Josephine County Airport Day and Family Nights at Tom Pearce Park. He also encouraged residents to sign up for emergency notifications and familiarize themselves with evacuation zones during wildfire season. Commissioner Smith thanked local firefighting agencies for their rapid response to a recent wildfire and commended emergency personnel for preventing further damage during challenging fire conditions.

Weekly Business Session adjourned at 9:56 a.m.



Nikole Guzman, Recorder